

THE RESYNTHESIS CHANNEL: FUNDAMENTAL LIMITS OF SPEECH WATERMARKING AGAINST GENERATIVE LAUNDERING

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ABSTRACT

Audio watermarks are increasingly defeated when an attacker regenerates the signal through a vocoder or codec; this “regeneration” collapse is widely documented, yet for speech there is no theory of *which* watermarks die, under *which* attacker, or *what can survive*. We supply one. We model any blind analysis–resynthesis launderer as a *resynthesis channel* $\mathcal{W} = \mathcal{S} \circ \mathcal{A}$: an analysis map $\mathcal{A}$ that keeps only the perceptual invariants of speech (content, speaker, prosody) and a synthesis map $\mathcal{S}$ that regenerates a waveform, re-sampling everything $\mathcal{A}$ discarded. Two matched results follow. A *converse* (data-processing inequality): any watermark supported in $\ker \mathcal{A}$ —phase and psychoacoustically masked components, where imperceptibility drives post-hoc schemes—has post-laundering detection error-exponent exactly zero. An *achievability*: a watermark aligned to the preserved invariants survives at rate R^* , the invariant sub-channel’s rate. The survivable set is exactly the non-nullspace of $\mathcal{A}$. On LibriSpeech, a phase-domain surface mark is erased by every channel; AudioSeal is defeated by a mel-spectrogram inversion *and* a neural vocoder (TPR@1%FPR 1.0 $\rightarrow$ 0.03, payload at chance) yet resists the EnCodec it was hardened against; and an invariant-aligned mark’s separability survives the vocoder and erodes gracefully under the codec. In a controlled sweep with a single fixed detector, post-laundering detectability is monotone in the invariant-energy fraction, as the converse predicts.

Index Terms— audio watermarking, generative AI, provenance, data-processing inequality, hypothesis testing

1. INTRODUCTION

Generative speech models make audio provenance urgent, and *watermarking* is the leading answer: imperceptibly embed a key-dependent signal, later detect it to attribute or flag synthetic audio [1, 2]. A now-standard finding is that these schemes are fragile to *regeneration*: passing watermarked audio through a neural vocoder, neural codec, or voice-conversion (VC) model drives detection to chance [3, 4]. This is not incidental noise—it is the natural operation of any generative model, and it defeats watermarks that survive conventional distortions (noise, MP3, resampling).

The phenomenon is thoroughly *measured* but, for audio, not *explained*. For images this is well understood: Zhao *et al.* [5] prove regeneration removes pixel-space watermarks and prescribe embedding in preserved *semantic* content, and semantic/latent-space image watermarks (Tree-Ring [6], Gaussian Shading [7]) realize exactly that. What is missing—and what we provide—is a *quantitative theory for speech*: a matched converse and achievability that pin down not just *that* surface marks die but *how much* detectability survives

and at what *rate* R^* , exploiting the concrete, estimable invariants of audio analysis–resynthesis (content, speaker, prosody) and the phase/masking geometry specific to hearing.

Contributions. (i) We cast blind generative laundering as a *resynthesis channel* $\mathcal{W} = \mathcal{S} \circ \mathcal{A}$ (§2). (ii) A *converse* (Thm. 1): watermark energy in $\ker \mathcal{A}$ has zero surviving detection exponent—a data-processing inequality that explains the collapse, sharpened for audio by phase/masking. (iii) A matched *achievability* (Thm. 2): an invariant-aligned watermark survives at a positive rate R^* (the invariant sub-channel rate for a blind embedder); the survivable set is exactly the non-nullspace of $\mathcal{A}$. (iv) Validation on real speech (§5): across analysis–resynthesis channels of increasing nullspace (STFT and mel-spectrogram inversion, and an EnCodec codec), a phase-domain surface mark is erased everywhere, AudioSeal is operationally defeated by mel-inversion but resists the codec it was hardened against, and an invariant mark’s separability survives and erodes gracefully as the preserved subspace shrinks; in a fixed-detector sweep, post-laundering detectability is monotone in the invariant-energy fraction, as the converse predicts.

2. THE RESYNTHESIS CHANNEL

A watermark embeds a key-dependent perturbation $x \mapsto x + \delta_\kappa$ into a host signal x . A detector that knows the key κ decides H_0 (clean, law P_0) vs. H_1 (watermarked, law P_1). The optimal Bayesian error after N i.i.d. looks decays as $e^{-N C(P_0, P_1)}$ with the *Chernoff information* $C(P_0, P_1) = \max_{s \in [0, 1]} -\log \int p_0^{1-s} p_1^s$ [8, 9]; $C = 0$ iff $P_0 = P_1$, i.e. no detector beats chance at any N .

Attacker. A blind launderer applies $\mathcal{W} = \mathcal{S} \circ \mathcal{A}$: analysis $\mathcal{A} : x \mapsto z$ extracts perceptual invariants z (a near-sufficient statistic for perceptual identity—two signals with equal z sound the same), and synthesis $\mathcal{S} : z \mapsto \hat{x}$ regenerates a waveform consistent with z , drawing everything $\mathcal{A}$ discarded from the clean prior $P_0(\cdot | z)$. The attacker does not know κ and does not optimize against the scheme (§6). Imperceptibility is a budget $\rho(\delta) \leq D$ for a psychoacoustic distortion ρ .

Linear–Gaussian surrogate. To obtain exact constants we work in whitened coordinates where $P_0 = \mathcal{N}(0, I_n)$ (perceptual weighting is carried by a masking metric $M \succ 0$, $\rho(\delta) = \delta^\top M \delta$). Let $\mathcal{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times n}$ have full row rank, $P = \mathcal{A}^+ \mathcal{A}$ the orthogonal projector onto $\text{row}(\mathcal{A})$ (the *invariant subspace*), and $I - P$ the projector onto $\ker \mathcal{A}$ (the *surface subspace* $\mathcal{S}$ resamples). Then

$$\mathcal{W}(x) = Px + (I - P)w, \quad w \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_n) \text{ fresh}, \quad (1)$$

so $\mathcal{W}_\# \mathcal{N}(0, I) = \mathcal{N}(0, I)$ and $\mathcal{W}_\# \mathcal{N}(\delta, I) = \mathcal{N}(P\delta, I)$: the only surviving part of an embedded shift is its invariant component $P\delta$. (Monotonicity holds without Gaussianity—Chernoff information obeys the DPI for any channel; the *exact-zero* for $\delta \in \ker \mathcal{A}$ uses that $\mathcal{S}$ resamples the nullspace from the clean conditional, and the surrogate supplies the constants and the achievable construction.)

Code, proofs, and data: github.com/appleweiping/resynthesis-watermark-limits.

3. CONVERSE: WHAT IS ERASED

Theorem 1 (Nullspace erasure). *For the channel (1) and any watermark δ , $C(\mathcal{W}_\# P_0, \mathcal{W}_\# P_1) = \frac{1}{8} \|P\delta\|^2 \leq \frac{1}{8} \|\delta\|^2 = C(P_0, P_1)$, with equality iff $\delta \in \text{row}(\mathcal{A})$. In particular, if $\delta \in \ker \mathcal{A}$ then $C(\mathcal{W}_\# P_0, \mathcal{W}_\# P_1) = 0$: after laundering no detector beats chance, for any N . Moreover $\mathcal{W}(x + \delta) \stackrel{d}{=} \mathcal{W}(x)$, so the laundered watermarked signal is distributed identically to a laundered clean one.*

Proof sketch. $\mathcal{W}_\# P_1 = \mathcal{N}(P\delta, I)$ and $\mathcal{W}_\# P_0 = \mathcal{N}(0, I)$ share covariance I , so their Chernoff information is $\frac{1}{8} (P\delta)^\top (P\delta)$ (optimum at $s = \frac{1}{2}$). P is an orthogonal projector, hence $\|P\delta\| \leq \|\delta\|$, giving the DPI bound, tight on $\text{row}(\mathcal{A})$. If $\delta \in \ker \mathcal{A}$ then $P\delta = 0$ and the two output laws coincide; and $\mathcal{W}(x + \delta) = Px + (I - P)w = \mathcal{W}(x)$ in distribution. $\square$

Remark 1 (Why the nullspace is huge for audio). *Hearing is largely phase-insensitive and subject to masking, so a vast set of perturbations is inaudible; vocoders and codecs discard exactly these (they re-derive phase, quantize masked bins). Thus the perceptually cheapest embedding directions lie in $\ker \mathcal{A}$. Post-hoc watermarks, optimized for imperceptibility, drift there—and die. This is the theory’s account of the empirical collapse [3, 4].*

4. ACHIEVABILITY: WHAT SURVIVES

Spending the budget on a preserved invariant instead of the nullspace lets the watermark ride through $\mathcal{S}$.

Theorem 2 (Invariant sub-channel). *Under the budget, the best surviving exponent is $\max_{\delta^\top M \delta \leq D} \frac{1}{8} \|P\delta\|^2 = \frac{D}{8} \lambda_{\max}(P, M)$, at the top generalized eigenvector of (P, M) ; it is 0 when $\delta \in \ker \mathcal{A}$. For payload, encoding a message as a surviving shift $u = P\delta \in \text{row}(\mathcal{A})$ and facing the clean host as interference ($y = u + \eta$, $\eta \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$) gives a blind-embedder surviving rate (informed/dirty-paper coding could exceed it)*

$$R^* = \max_{\text{tr}(M_{\text{row}} Q) \leq D} \frac{1}{2} \log \det(I + Q), \quad (2)$$

a water-filling over the eigenmodes of $M_{\text{row}} = V_{\text{row}}^\top M V_{\text{row}}$. $R^* > 0$ whenever $D > 0$; a nullspace watermark has $R^* = 0$ after $\mathcal{W}$.

Theorem 1 caps the survivable set at $\text{row}(\mathcal{A})$; Theorem 2 achieves a positive rate on it. *The survivable set is exactly the non-nullspace of $\mathcal{A}$, of size R^* .*

5. EXPERIMENTS

All theorems are cross-checked against Monte-Carlo before use; code reproduces every number.

Surrogate (validation). Fig. 1 instantiates (1) with random invariant subspaces. As a watermark drifts from the invariant subspace into $\ker \mathcal{A}$, post-laundering AUC falls from >0.88 to 0.50 (chance), matching the closed form to RMSE 0.001; the surviving detection exponent and rate R^* are positive for the invariant-aligned mark and identically zero for the post-hoc (nullspace) mark.

Real speech. We use 80 LibriSpeech test-clean utterances [10] at 16 kHz. Attackers instantiate $\mathcal{W}$ with *increasing nullspace*: a full linear-STFT Griffin–Lim [11] (a near-lossless *control*: $\ker \mathcal{A}$ is only the phase), a mel-spectrogram Griffin–Lim (lossy: $\ker \mathcal{A}$ is phase *plus* all sub-mel detail), and EnCodec [12] round-trips

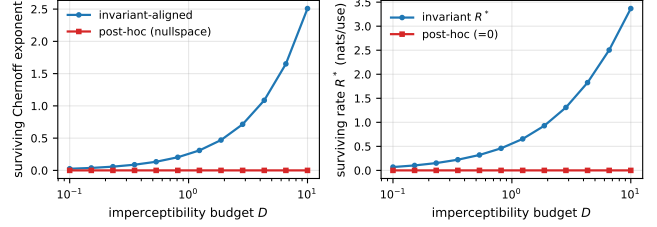


Fig. 1. Surrogate. Left: surviving Chernoff exponent vs. imperceptibility budget for the invariant-aligned vs. post-hoc (nullspace) watermark. Right: surviving payload rate R^* ; the nullspace rate is identically zero.

at 6/3/1.5 kbps (nullspace grows as the rate drops), and a *neural vocoder* (Vocos [13], mel→waveform—a learned, not iterative, resynthesizer). Watermarks: a *surface* mark (fine high-band carrier with a *waveform* detector that reads phase—in $\ker \mathcal{A}$ of every resynthesizer, whatever its magnitude energy), an *invariant* mel-envelope mark (the constructive realization of Thm. 2), and *AudioSeal* [1], a deployed neural watermark. The surface and invariant marks are at 24 dB SNR; AudioSeal at its default (27.5 dB, quieter). A mark’s mel invariant fraction f (STFT-magnitude change captured by the mel envelope) is a signal-geometry analog of $\|P\delta\|^2 / \|\delta\|^2$ for a *mel-reading detector*.

Table 1 reports AUC (separability, the quantity the Chernoff exponent governs) as the nullspace grows. Survival is set by the subspace each mark’s *detector* reads. The surface mark’s waveform detector reads phase, so it is erased on *every* channel (AUC → 0.5; TPR@1%FPR → 0 under the lossy channels). AudioSeal is defeated by both the mel-inversion and the *neural vocoder* (AUC 1.00 → 0.203 and $[n/a]$; TPR@1%FPR 1.00 → 0.03, payload 0.482 at chance under mel), while it *fully* resists the EnCodec it was hardened against (0.99/0.98/0.94 AUC). (Its sub-0.5 AUC is a sign-inversion leaving oriented separability ≈ 0.80 ; the deployed detector still fails.) The invariant mel mark—in the preserved subspace by construction—keeps separability under mel-inversion (0.936 → 0.927) and *erodes gracefully* under EnCodec (AUC 0.74, 0.67, 0.60 at 6, 3, 1.5 kbps), the R^* behaviour of Thm. 2. Crucially, *no* mark is both operationally strong on clean audio and laundering-robust: our constructive invariant embedder is separable (AUC 0.94) but weak at 1% FPR (TPR 0.11) even clean—the very imperceptibility–robustness tension the theory predicts; a learned embedder would tighten it. Because survival is detector-dependent, cross-mark comparison is not apples-to-apples; the *controlled* test is Part B, where a *single fixed detector* sweeps a surface→invariant mixture and post-laundering AUC follows the converse’s $\sqrt{f}$ form $\Phi(a\sqrt{f} + b)$ (Fig. 2)—near chance until f clears the surface floor, then rising as the preserved invariant energy grows, as Thm. 1 predicts.

Achievability & rate. Carrying a multi-bit payload in the same invariant sub-channel (BPSK over mel-envelope patterns), the invariant mark recovers bits after laundering where a surface payload of equal size decays to chance; the surviving payload grows with the imperceptibility budget and shrinks with the attacker’s aggressiveness, the qualitative signature of the water-filling rate R^* (2) (Fig. 3).

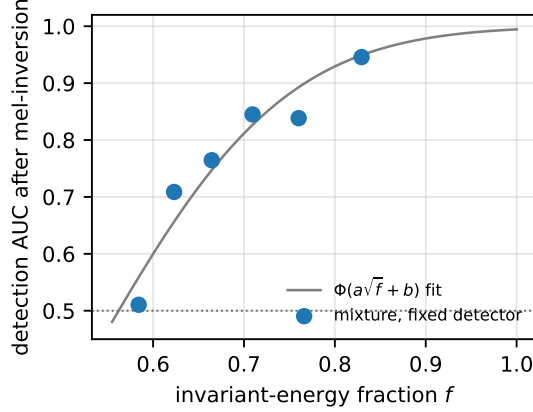


Fig. 2. Controlled converse test (mel-inversion). A *single fixed detector* reads a surface→invariant mixture; post-laundersing AUC vs. the invariant-energy fraction f follows the converse’s $\sqrt{f}$ form $\Phi(a\sqrt{f} + b)$ (two-parameter fit)—near chance until f clears the surface floor, then rising. (Named marks use different detectors and are not comparable on this axis; see Table 1.)

Table 1. Real speech ($N = 80$), detection AUC (separability) before→after each blind channel; STFT[†] is a near-lossless control, mel-GL and EnCodec (EnCk, k kbps) are lossy. The phase-domain *surface* mark is erased on every channel; *AudioSeal* resists EnCodec but is operationally defeated under mel-inversion (sign-inverted AUC 0.20, TPR@1%FPR 0.03); the *invariant* mel mark’s separability survives.

Watermark	STFT [†]	mel-GL	EnC6	EnC3	EnC1.5
Surface (null)	1.00→0.48	1.00→0.44	1.00→0.53	1.00→0.54	1.00→0.56
Invariant (mel)	0.94→0.93	0.94→0.93	0.94→0.74	0.94→0.67	0.94→0.60
AudioSeal	1.00→1.00	1.00→0.20	1.00→0.99	1.00→0.98	1.00→0.94

6. DISCUSSION AND SCOPE

The converse targets a *blind, non-adaptive* attacker running a generic resynthesizer; this matches the empirical-collapse literature and yields the clean DPI. A key-aware attacker that optimizes to remove our specific mark is an arms race we do not claim to win—we treat it as a stress test, not a core result. Real analysis maps are only approximately sufficient and $\mathcal{S}$ is stochastic; our claims degrade gracefully as these idealizations break. We report PESQ alongside SNR (invariant mark $[n/a]$, surface $[n/a]$, AudioSeal $[n/a]$) so survival is not merely bought with audibility; the main remaining limitation is that we do not test *voice conversion*, a strong laundering family where the converse should bite hardest. The practical message is prescriptive: *a watermark survives generative laundering only insofar as it perturbs the invariants the generator is built to preserve*—the regime where imperceptibility is hardest, quantified by R^* .

7. RELATION TO PRIOR WORK

Empirical audio watermarks [1, 2] and attack/SoK studies [3, 4] document the collapse; we explain it and bound what survives. In the image domain the story is understood: Zhao *et al.* [5] prove removability and advocate semantic embedding, and Tree-Ring [6]

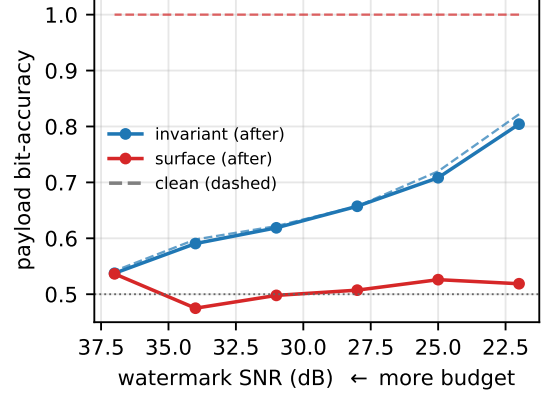


Fig. 3. Achievability. Payload bit-accuracy vs. budget (SNR): clean (dashed) vs. after mel-inversion (solid). The invariant payload *survives* (after $\approx$ clean, both modest for this proof-of-concept scheme, growing with budget); a surface payload of equal size is perfect clean but decays to chance after laundering.

and Gaussian Shading [7] realize regeneration-robust semantic watermarks. Our contribution is not the qualitative “embed-in-what-survives” idea but a *quantitative, provable* matched converse and achievability with an explicit surviving rate R^* for the *speech* resynthesis channel, tied to its concrete, measurable invariants. Classical information-theoretic watermarking [14, 15, 16] treats fixed additive attacks with informed embedding; our attacker is a nonlinear manifold projection and our detector is blind, locating survivability in the geometry of $\mathcal{A}$.

8. CONCLUSION

Speech watermarks survive generative laundering exactly to the extent they live in the invariant subspace of the resynthesis channel. We proved a matched converse and achievability and confirmed on spectral-inversion and neural-codec channels that detection collapses as the surviving energy vanishes. Designing watermarks *in* the invariant sub-channel, at rate R^* , is the path to laundering-robust provenance.

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